

CONSUMER GUIDE: REALTORS® DUTY TO PUT CLIENT INTERESTS ABOVE THEIR OWN

A [REALTOR®](#) is a special kind of real estate agent: one who follows NAR's strict Code of Ethics, including the first and primary pledge to protect and promote the interests of their clients. This obligation means that a REALTOR® cannot make decisions or provide representation in a way that puts their own interests or commissions ahead of their clients' interests.

What does it mean for a REALTOR® to act in a BUYER's best interest? A REALTOR® has an ethical duty to tell a buyer about every home available for sale that meets their criteria. That means that REALTORS® will let you know about all available homes, regardless of whether the seller or listing broker is offering compensation to your buyer's agent, and even if compensation offered by a seller or listing broker is less than what you agreed to pay your agent in your written buyer agreement.

What does it mean for a REALTOR® to act in a SELLER's best interest? A REALTOR® should explain to their seller the benefits and costs of the various types of marketing that can be done for a listing, and how potential buyers might respond to such marketing. A REALTOR® is ethically prohibited from telling a seller that their home will be hidden from buyers unless the seller pays a particular type or amount of compensation.

What is wrongful "steering"? The REALTOR® Code of Ethics prohibits "steering" buyers toward homes because the REALTOR® will be paid more, or away from homes because the REALTOR® will be paid less. Similarly, the REALTOR® Code of Ethics prohibits a REALTOR® from telling a seller that buyers will be "steered" toward homes because the REALTOR® will be paid more, or away from homes because the REALTOR® will be paid less.

How do written agreements protect me from steering? As of August 17, 2024, you will be asked to sign a written buyer agreement before touring a home with the professional you want to work with. NAR's ethical rules have long encouraged REALTORS® to enter into written agreements with their clients because these agreements promote clarity and transparency. They also help protect you from wrongful "steering" by specifying the amount of compensation the REALTOR® will receive and the services they will provide. Since a broker working with a buyer receives the amount the buyer has agreed to, the amount of any offer of compensation is irrelevant to the buyer-broker's compensation.

Where can I learn more about buyer agreements? NAR has created a dedicated resource on written buyer agreements [here](#).

What can I do if I think a REALTOR® is violating NAR's Code of Ethics? If a REALTOR® acts in a way that places their interests before yours, this is a violation of NAR's Code of Ethics and should be reported to your [state or local REALTOR® Association](#) for investigation and potential disciplinary action.

Please visit [facts.realtor](#) for more information and resources, and consult your real estate professional or attorney for details about state law where you are purchasing a home.

SELLER CHECKLIST: 15 THINGS TO DO BEFORE EVERY SHOWING

You're ready to sell your home. You have consulted with an agent who's a REALTOR® and done everything you can to maximize your chances of selling: You've decluttered, depersonalized, deep cleaned, made necessary repairs and staged the home to make it as appealing as possible. Now, here's a handy checklist of the things to do before every showing to help your home sell faster and for top dollar.

FLOORS AND SURFACES

- ☐ **Pick up.** Be sure beds are made and toys, clothes and other articles are picked up and put away.
- ☐ **Clear kitchen and bath counters.** The less you have out, the more spacious counters look. Leave big items, like a toaster oven or coffee maker. Neatly stow everything else in drawers and cabinets.
- ☐ **Wipe down all surfaces.** Use a damp cloth to wipe down dining tables, tea tables, side tables and bookshelves where dust may be visible.

KITCHEN

- ☐ **Wipe down handles, knobs and doors.** High-traffic appliances like the refrigerator, microwave, stove, and cabinets always attract fingerprints.
- ☐ **Organize your refrigerator.** Buyers *will* open it and look inside and judge you on what they see. Make sure things are neatly organized and clean.
- ☐ **Neutralize odors.** Refrain from cooking foods with strong odors in the hours before a showing. Search for "stovetop potpourri" for recipe ideas to make your home smell great.

BATHROOMS

- ☐ **Swap out towels.** Put away the towels you use, and put up clean, new staging towels.
- ☐ **Wipe down mirrors.** Removing visible smudge marks will make the entire space look cleaner.

VALUABLES

- ☐ **Hide jewelry and other valuables.**
- ☐ **Secure firearms and priceless collectibles.**
- ☐ **Put away electronic devices.**
- ☐ **Hide prescription medications.**

EXTERIOR PATHWAYS

- ☐ **Clear pathways.** Sweep any debris, snow or ice from any pathways leading to your home.

FINAL CHECK

- ☐ **Open all the window treatments and turn on ALL the lights.** Even in broad daylight, turning on the lights will help make the space feel bright.
- ☐ **Disable the alarm and take your pets with you.** Potential buyers may have allergies or other reasons for avoiding pets; it's best to eliminate any potential issues.

OPTIONAL WELCOMING TOUCH

- ☐ **Provide refreshments.** Leave out a tray of cookies and water bottles for the potential homebuyers to enjoy while viewing your home.

These steps may seem overwhelming at first, but you will soon find your groove and be able to get ready for showings in less than an hour.

Additional Resource: [Before Putting a Home Up for Sale](#)

Your real estate agent will help you navigate the purchase or sale of a home. An attorney can provide guidance on the laws in the state where you're purchasing. Only real estate professionals who are members of the National Association of REALTORS® may use the term REALTOR®. Under the NAR's Code of Ethics, REALTORS® must work in their client's best interest and treat all parties fairly. Please visit [factsrealtor](https://www.factsrealtor.com) for more information and resources.